

HOW THE INDIANS FARED

Of the five debutant Indians in the 2024 Candidates, D. Gukesh went on to claim the title in the open section, where an eight-man field included four from the world's top-10 list.

The other four – two in each section – also had their moments. If R. Praggnanandhaa played to his rating and seeding, Vidit Gujrathi had the rare distinction of beating World No. 3 Hikaru Nakamura twice. If third-ranked Koneru Humpy showed steely resolve to bounce back from a poor start to finish joint-runner, young R. Vaishali matched her senior compatriot's tally by dramatically rising from a four-game losing streak to finish the campaign with five straight victories.

Here are the Candidates' report cards of these four Indians. Read on...

Rakesh Rao

R Praggnanandhaa came to Toronto with the seasoned Russian Grandmaster Peter Svidler as part of his team. In spite of playing to his rating, he was left to rue a few missed chances, including one against Gukesh in the second round, which he eventually lost. His



opening preparation clearly stood out, and he was seldom in any trouble going into the middle game. Clearly, he could shift gears when needed.

Looking back, Praggnanandhaa was sure to reflect on his fifth-round clash against Ian Nepomniachtchi, whom he out-prepared in the opening phase and then missed a possible victory before agreeing for a draw.

In fact, his seven-game winless streak, from Round 8 to 13, including losses to Nakamura and Caruana, effectively pushed him out of the title race.

Of his three victories, including two against last-man Nijat Abasov, the one with black pieces against Vidit was well-crafted. Praggnanandhaa's losses to the two Americans — Nakamura and Caruana — late in the competition must have taught the youngster a lot.

In both these encounters, he played white but could not deal with the superiority of these two players, who are considered the strongest after Magnus Carlsen in the past decade.

Overall, Praggnanandhaa can draw strength from the fact that, despite being a debutant, he could play to his seeding in such a challenging field.

He won and lost an equal number of games. He will remember his first Candidates as the one where he could have clearly done better.

R. Praggnanandhaa

Rank
5th

Seeding
5

Rating
2747

Performance Rating
2745

Rating points lost
0.4

Points scored – 7/14

Rd	Seed	Opponent	Country	Rating	Colour	Result	Rank
1	3	Alireza Firouzja	France	2760	Black	Draw	7th
2	6	D. Gukesh	India	2743	White	Lost	1st
3	7	Vidit Gujrathi	India	2727	Black	Won	6th
4	2	Hikaru Nakamura	USA	2789	Black	Draw	Tied 2nd
5	4	Ian Nepomniachtchi	FIDE	2758	White	Draw	Tied 2nd
6	8	Nijat Abasov	Azerbaijan	2632	White	Won	8th
7	1	Fabiano Caruana	USA	2803	Black	Draw	Tied 2nd
8	3	Alireza Firouzja	France	2760	White	Draw	7th
9	6	D. Gukesh	India	2743	Black	Draw	1st
10	7	Vidit Gujrathi	India	2727	White	Draw	6th
11	2	Hikaru Nakamura	USA	2789	White	Lost	Tied 2nd
12	4	Ian Nepomniachtchi	FIDE	2758	Black	Draw	Tied 2nd
13	1	Fabiano Caruana	USA	2803	White	Lost	4th
14	8	Nijat Abasov	Azerbaijan	2632	Black	Won	8th